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ENC 1101
9/24/2026

Downs and Kairos

Downs writes “kairos which translates to something like “timely good fortune” or simply “lucky timing” Kairos is the principle that rhetors have far-from-complete control of their texts and discourses, because circumstances beyond their control can intervene to change the moment and what it makes sense to say in that moment.” (page 467) Rhetoric focuses on persuasion and convincing people of certain ideas; however, there will always be things a rhetor cannot control. This is the principle Downs describes as kairos. A rhetor may attempt to convince a reader that smoking is healthy, only for evidence to reveal only a few years later that smoking has serious health concerns. More recently, when I visited UCF’s engineering building II, I found myself in awe of the building’s lobby. While the lobby is designed to be a place of collaboration, I found myself feeling excluded and uncomfortable exploring the lobby during my visit in the middle of the day. In the middle of the day, the room is the most crowded, every seat was taken by a focused individual, this made me feel out of place. So despite the room being designed to encourage people to linger, when the context of the room shifts to crowded, people just entering the space may feel out of place.